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RE: **Clarification of VGIC's Recommendations on Technical Standards and Certifications of Bidirectional Charging Systems for the Energy Storage Solutions Program**

VGIC seeks to clarify its recommendations regarding the technical standards and certification requirements used to determine eligibility for bidirectional charging systems under the Energy Storage Solutions (ESS) program. As bidirectional charging solutions continue to evolve, program eligibility criteria must reflect both established safety standards and the current state of commercially available solutions, without inadvertently excluding viable commercially available systems that can meaningfully support the grid.

Recommendation #1: Separate Requirements for DC and AC Bidirectional Charging Systems

Technical standards and certification requirements should be established separately for DC and AC bidirectional charging systems. This distinction is consistent with existing interconnection frameworks, which recognize the fundamental differences in how these distinct bidirectional charging architectures are certified and deployed. Aligning ESS program eligibility requirements with this structure will help ensure clarity and reduce ambiguity for participants, program administrators, and technology providers.

Recommendation #2: Align ESS Program Requirements with Distribution System Interconnection Requirements

To further bolster clarity and reduce ambiguity, the standards and required certifications for bidirectional charging system ESS program eligibility should be mapped to the requirements for safe and reliable distribution system interconnection. Requirements for

ESS program eligibility that do not also appear in the relevant interconnection requirements should be identified with a clear explanation as to why the standard or certification is required.

Recommendation #3: Provide a Grace Period for Equipment That Does Not Meet Program Communication Protocols Eligibility Requirements

VGIC appreciates the importance of and supports advancing toward a robust and interoperable bidirectional charging ecosystem, including through the use of open standards, which may include ISO 15118-20 Amendment 1 for Bidirectional Power Transfer (BPT) and the Open Charge Point Protocol (OCPP), Version 2.1. These standards are likely to play an important role over the long term in enabling greater interoperability across vehicles, charging equipment, and charge station management platforms.

At the same time, the market for bidirectional charging remains in a nascent stage of development. Many commercially available systems today rely on proprietary or alternative communication approaches and would not meet strict compliance requirements if imposed today. Establishing near-term eligibility requirements tied to these protocols risks excluding viable products currently in the market, thereby limiting participation, slowing the pace of early deployment and learning, and restricting the magnitude of system peak load reduction and, in turn, the benefits that can accrue to all ratepayers.

Connecticut is taking a leadership role as one of the first jurisdictions to move from one-off demonstrations toward full integration of bidirectional charging systems into a customer program. As such, program design must reflect current market realities while allowing the industry a chance to mature. VGIC recommends establishing a defined grace period during which bidirectional charging systems that are not yet designed to open standards remain eligible for program participation. This approach would enable continued market development while providing a clear signal that interoperability standards will become increasingly important over time.

A time-bound grace period, paired with a commitment to revisit communication protocol requirements in future program years, strikes an appropriate balance between supporting market transformation and unlocking customer benefits (both for participating customers and non-participating ratepayers) without compromising long-term interoperability goals. This phased approach will help ensure that early market momentum is not disrupted while positioning the program to transition toward standardized, interoperable solutions as

design and certification frameworks (e.g., IEA Task 53), testing infrastructure (e.g., CharIN Testivals and California's new Capital Charge Yard), and commercially available products continue to evolve.

Recommendation #4: Coordinate the Consideration of Technical Requirements with that of Incentive Structure

As a general note, VGIC recognizes that any program design elements that provide equipment rebates should be balanced to avoid deploying assets that may later become stranded. However, it is unclear at this stage of the Bidirectional EV Working Group whether the resulting report and recommendations to PURA will advise that equipment rebates be provided. VGIC posits that *if* equipment rebates are *not* provided, the concern over stranded assets would be eliminated, as program funds would not be placed at risk in the first place.

Thank you for considering these recommendations. VGIC would be happy to meet to discuss or clarify any of the above recommendations at your convenience.

Sincerely,



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